

Meltdown MAKEOVER

Classic cuts and strong design details dominate the Lakme Fashion Week as designers cut costs to beat the financial slump

| By Jhilmil Motihar |

What's better than a cut-to-perfection raw silk shift dress? Two raw silk shifts, of course. And when you get two at the price of one, it's called a style spasm. This might seem like an advertisement for a very good sale, but it is actually designer Rahul Mishra's autumn-winter collection. The designer, aware of the Indian customer's affinity for penny pinching, especially at a time when recession has become the most-Googled word, has tailored a collection called 'Reversing the Recession'. Each garment can be worn both sides, inside out. "More than anything else, at this point the Indian customer needs a garment that is value for money," says Mishra,

whose prices are between Rs 5,000 and 15,000.

At the Lakme Fashion Week Autumn-Winter 2009 in Mumbai, bling was out and basics were in. Overcoming the hype around international buyers, designers woke up to the fact that if their collections need to make commercial sense it is the Indian buyer they need to aggressively woo. They don't have a choice. Unlike previous seasons, the number of international buyers in Mumbai was down from close to 30 to just about eight. The Indian buyers, thankfully, remained consistent. "The recession hasn't hit India as much. People are still buying. It's what they are buying that has changed," says Alka Nishar, owner of multi-designer store Aza.

The result is heavy embroidery that significantly adds to the cost of a garment has given way to richer fabrics and textures. They look opulent and



All About the Metal

Silver made a huge return to the ramp, with designers like Gurpreet Pia Fleming creating dresses with crushed metallic fabric for her label Bian (L). Nachiket Barve once again played with rich hues of indigo to bestow his intricately detailed shifts with lavishness.

MANDAR DEODHAR



SHRITA PATIL SHINDE

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More for less was going through designer Rahul Mishra's (above) mind when he created his collection, 'Reversing the Recession'. High on style, the garments could be worn both sides, inside out. He didn't skimp on materials using rich fabrics like raw silk and Banarsi satin but says that instead of wasting fabric he used it wisely.